

Official Curtis Riggleman

BUILT TO LEAD: MINDSET PRINCIPLES

BOOK FOUR

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Curtis Riggleman



Built to Lead, Mindset Principles

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www.officialcurtisriggleman.com

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BUILT TO LEAD Mindset Principles

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Introduction

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN IN THIS BOOK:

- What makes someone a leader?
- The mindset of a leader.
- Daily habits of a leader.
- How to earn the respects of your peers.
- How to get people motivated to impress you and work for you.
- Learn about your strengths and challenges
- How to set audacious goals and achieve them!
- How to motivate all age groups in your staff.
- How to build leaders

Once you learn the techniques in this book, you will notice that your team is more motivated overall, and that they are excited to work for you.

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My Story

I Wasn't Supposed to Win.

I didn't grow up with opportunity, structure, or guidance. I grew up in chaos. Both of my parents were drug addicts, and for most of my childhood, we were homeless. School wasn't consistent—we moved constantly, and survival was the priority, not education.

My dad was a career criminal, stealing whatever he could to support his addiction. Most of the food we ate was stolen. The cars we drove—and often slept in—were stolen. More than once, we watched from a distance as the police towed away everything we had.

That kind of life forces you to grow up fast.

At 13 years old, my dad was arrested again for GTA with priors and sentenced to 10 years, serving 7. My mom was still deep in addiction and mostly absent. Around that time, I managed to

rent a room on Motel Drive in Fresno, California. I looked older than I was, and no one questioned it. These were the kind of motels you could rent by the hour, so they didn't ask many questions.

My brother and I lived in that motel room for the next five years.

I stopped going to school completely. I became a car thief to survive. That was my reality. To this day, I still only have an 8th-grade education.

But even in that life, I had something different.

I had a belief.

I became extremely competitive in everything I did. That mindset carried over into the streets, and I became the #1 car thief in my area, stealing over 5,000 cars in four years. People around me looked at me like I was successful. I always had nice cars. I lived fast. In that environment, that made me a hero.

But I never believed that was my future.

I told everyone the same thing:

"This is temporary. I'm going to make it out of this. I'm going to be rich, and my kids will never live like this."

I didn't know how—but I believed it.

I didn't realize it at the time, but I was programming my mind. Eventually, I believed it so strongly that it felt real before it ever happened.

Growing up like that teaches you things no school ever could. You learn how to read people. You learn how to tell when someone is lying. You learn how people think, how they react, and what drives them. You also develop thick skin. When you've already lived through the worst, fear of the unknown doesn't control you anymore.

That would later become one of my greatest advantages.

The First Shift

Eventually, I started working for an older man named Bob Papazian.

Bob treated me like a son. He took me under his wing and started teaching me about life, discipline, and how to think like a businessman. He was 80 years old and still worked every single day. He didn't care where I came from—he only cared about where I was going.

He paid me \$4.75 an hour under the table.

It wasn't enough to live on, so I was still stealing cars after work just to survive. But what Bob gave me was far more valuable than money—he gave me perspective.

After three years, I asked him for a raise.

He told me something that stuck with me for life:

“You should be paying me for everything I've taught you.”

At the time, that wasn't what I wanted to hear—but he was right.

Looking back, I'm grateful he didn't give me that raise. If he had, I probably would have stayed. Instead, I left—and that decision changed everything.

The Turning Point

I decided I wanted to become a truck driver. After a couple of months of trying, I ended up walking into a car dealership to apply for a sales job.

One dealership looked at me and said,

“How do you expect to get hired looking like that?”

I thought I looked good. I had on my best clothes.

They told me to leave, buy better clothes, and come back.

Instead, I walked across the street to another dealership.

After two hours of interviews with three different managers, they gave me a shot—with one

condition: show up the next day dressed better.

I borrowed money from a friend, bought new clothes, and came back ready.

Then I met someone who would change my life—Robert Tucker.

For 10 straight days, he trained me 8 hours a day. No shortcuts. No half effort. Just pure focus on learning the craft.

On December 16, 2001, I talked to my first customer.

It was my first sale—and my first unwind.

But I didn't stop.

I sold 10 more cars that month.

Then I got my first paycheck.

\$5,100... for two weeks of work.

That moment changed everything.

For the first time in my life, I had clarity. I knew exactly how I was going to become rich.

Obsession and Growth

From that point on, I became obsessed.

I studied. I practiced. I improved every day. My competitive drive took over, and I refused to lose. My ability to read people made everything click. What I learned growing up became an advantage.

I became the top salesman. Then the top closer in an auto group of 126 stores.

I fixed my credit—the same credit my parents had damaged when I was a kid. Before I was even an adult, I had collections in my name. Back then, people could put things under their kids' names.

I bought my first house in 2002. Then two more in 2003. Two more in 2004. Two more in 2005.

In 2005, I leveraged one property to open a poker store and put my brother in charge.

By 2006—just five years into the business—I was a millionaire on paper.

That same year, I leveraged another property and bought my own car lot.

Losing Everything

Then 2008 hit.

I lost everything during the depression. I don't blame the depression I blame myself for not being better prepared.

I had to move my family out of our home. I went through a period of depression. Everything I built was gone.

But I didn't stay there.

I went back to the same dealership where I started—with my pen in hand.

At that time, nobody was making money. It was one of the worst times in the industry.

But I was hungry again.

I had a chip on my shoulder, and I wanted everything back.

This time, I was starting over \$2 million in debt.

The Comeback

In my first month back, I sold 28 cars and made just under \$20,000.

In four months, I sold 100 cars—more than double the next closest salesperson.

The GM asked me to step into management and train the team.

I did.

Within six months, we became the #1 store in town.

At the same time I started repaying my debt repairing my credit and preparing my next run at success, it took me 10 years to pay off the IRS and every dollar I owed.

Where I Am Today

Along the way, I've trained and developed thousands successful of sales people. Saving them decades of time from my own trails.

As of February 2026, I own 10 homes valued at \$5.5 million, two businesses, and I'm part owner in six dealerships. I currently oversee 10 of the most successful dealerships in Fresno County.

But none of that is the most important part.

Why This Books Exists

Everything in this book comes from real experience.

Not theory. Not opinions.

Trial and error. Failure and growth. Wins and losses.

If I knew back then what I know now, I would be miles ahead of where I am today.

That's why I wrote this.

So you don't have to learn everything the hard way.

Top 50 Mindset Principles:

In this book, I'm giving you my top 50 habits, traits, and mindset principles that helped me become the leader I am today.

1. Clear Vision

Leaders operate with a clearly defined picture of where they are going, which gives direction to every decision they make. Without vision, people tend to react to circumstances instead of shaping outcomes intentionally. A strong vision acts as a filter, helping leaders say no to distractions and yes to what truly matters. It also provides motivation during difficult periods because the long-term goal remains meaningful. I personally have to have short term goals to stay focused on my long term goals, I need those wins. In hindsight its probably takes me a little longer to get to my long term goals but those wins in between keep me moving forward and staying focused on the long term. The vision sometimes changes, pivoting is not quitting sometime you'll have to shift gears from your original plan. That's ok we all do.

Example: I may be working toward something and along the way as I realize im going to achieve this goal it may not interest me as much as it did 6 months ago, I may have to raise that goal and look passed it to keep that same motivation.

2. Take Action

Strong leaders take action quickly instead of waiting for perfect conditions or overthinking decisions. They understand that progress comes from execution, not just planning or talking. Taking action creates momentum and reveals real-world feedback that leads to improvement. They are willing to make adjustments along the way rather than delaying for certainty. Over time, this habit separates them from those who stay stuck in hesitation.

Example: A leader knows waiting for the right time or for the perfect scenario is another form of procrastination, if you don't take action you will eventually move on from that idea and have a reason to justify not trying and like anything this will only get easier to do. There are talkers and doers you have to make a decision which are you.

3. Discipline Over Motivation

Motivation is temporary and inconsistent, while discipline ensures consistent action over time. Leaders understand that success comes from doing what needs to be done even when they don't feel like it. They build routines and systems that reduce reliance on mood or external inspiration. This creates reliability, which is essential when others depend on them. Over time, discipline becomes a competitive advantage because most people quit when things feel difficult. I have a saying: "Discipline will get you going. Results will keep you going." If you don't have the discipline to do the not-so-fun stuff you'll never see the results!

Example: Asking our sales reps or team to do the things we don't like doing (like phone work) instead of helping them get it done is not good leadership. If we as leaders can't show the discipline to get it done, how can we expect them to?

4. Long-Term Thinking

Leaders prioritize decisions that create sustainable success rather than immediate gratification. They understand that short-term wins can sometimes undermine long-term growth if not managed carefully. This perspective helps them invest in skills, relationships, and systems that compound over time. It also allows them to remain patient when results are not immediate. Over time, this approach leads to stronger and more stable success.

Example: In the early 2000's there were more traveling sales trainers than today. Of course the internet has changed all that. I wanted to become better. I bought some daily workshops with the goal of gaining 1 piece of knowledge that I could use to double my money in the current year. That expectation was very low. What happened instead is that I came away with 4 or 5 action steps. I discovered that I could earn 4 or 5 times my investment back. That is winning long-term. Investing in my own education set me apart and help me pass the short-term thinkers. Others would use the excuses that they were too busy, or didn't want to miss a car deal. Focused only on the now has cost them far more time than a day of selling cars.

5. Consistency

Consistency is the ability to show up and perform repeatedly over time, regardless of circumstances. This builds trust because others can rely on your steady performance. It also leads to compounding results, where progress accelerates over time. Consistency separates serious performers from those who only act when convenient. When you are inconsistent it confuses your staff, they never know which one of you is showing up today. It makes it hard for your staff to fully respect you when they know based on history that you may not follow through.

Example: Managers and sales reps being inconsistent is one of the most common failures I see today. When we hold people accountable based on our mood, or when we have a huge success and then don't keep working hard for another, trying for more, you are settling for inconsistency. If you want to get to that next next level you have to be consistent in everything you do.

6. Growth Mindset

Leaders with this mindset embrace challenges instead of avoiding them. They view failures as feedback rather than losses. This allows them to continuously improve and adapt in changing environments. Over time, they become more capable because they never stop learning.

Example: when you have a growth mindset you become addicted to success, you stop chasing money and start chasing growth and achievements and as a byproduct the money flows better than before.

7. Grit

Grit is the ability to keep going when things are hard, uncertain, or not going your way. Strong leaders don't rely on motivation—they rely on their willingness to push through discomfort, setbacks, and failure. Grit means showing up every day with the same intensity, regardless of how you feel or what obstacles are in front of you. It's the difference between people who quit when things get tough and those who keep going until they win. Over time, grit becomes one of the biggest factors in long-term success because it allows you to outlast and outperform others.

Example: After losing everything in 2008 and being \$2 million in debt, I went back to the same dealership where I started, sold 28 cars my first month and started my journey back. Losing everything you worked for and starting over is extremely stressful but my grit would not allow me to fail. My hunger was greater, the chip on my shoulder was bigger. I felt like something was stolen from me and I had to get it back. I heard a quote once: “Your ability to handle stress & pressure is your ceiling to success.”

8. Emotional Intelligence

Emotional intelligence involves recognizing, understanding, and managing both your own emotions and those of others. Leaders with high emotional intelligence handle conflict more effectively and build stronger relationships. They are able to stay composed under pressure, which stabilizes their teams. This skill also improves communication and trust. Over time, it creates a more positive and productive work environment. A true leader can make everyone stay and feel calm in high stress environments.

Example: If my stores had a really tough weekend and I saw that morale was down, I would sometimes call a meeting. I would encourage them by saying, “We just went through one of the toughest weeks of the year and we didn't lose anyone. It's behind us now, so shake it off because the rest of the month has been amazing.” Emotional intelligence is not only the ability to control ur own emotions but also influence the emotions of others

9. Strong Work Ethic

A strong work ethic means consistently putting in the effort required to achieve high-level results. Leaders don't rely on talent alone; they combine it with dedication and persistence. This sets the standard for others and creates a culture of effort and excellence. It also ensures that important tasks are completed thoroughly. Over time, this reputation leads to more opportunities and trust.

Example: If you have been in sales any length of time, we've all seen the guy with all the talent but his laziness prevents him from ever achieving. And we've seen the guy who still has things to learn but who works harder than everyone else move up the chain. The reality is talent is easier to teach than work ethic. So if you lack the talent right now, then pivot to outworking everyone else. As you build your skills (talent), keep your work ethic- you will achieve more than you ever dreamed possible.

10. Never Satisfied

Strong leaders are never fully satisfied because they are always striving to improve and reach the next level. They take pride in their achievements, but don't become comfortable or complacent. This mindset pushes them to continuously raise their standards and expectations. It keeps them growing even when they are already performing at a high level. Over time, this drive creates consistent progress and separates them from those who settle.

Example: After hitting a major goal, a leader immediately evaluates what can be improved and sets a higher target instead of relaxing or slowing down. Don't confuse this with never being happy. They are not the same. The truth is leaders are often very happy because we have purpose and progress. Never being satisfied simply means that for us, it's not just being driven by achievement, it's being driven by possibility. Now what's next?

11. Continuous Learning

Top performers commit to learning as an on-going, never-ending process rather than something that stops after formal education. They actively seek new knowledge, skills, and perspectives to stay relevant and competitive. This habit allows them to adapt to change and seize new opportunities faster than others. It also keeps their thinking sharp and prevents stagnation. Over time, continuous learning compounds into expertise and a strong competitive advantage. As a leader it's your responsibility to continue getting information, if you are not growing, how can you continue to keep your team interested?

Example: When I got into the business in 2001, there was a lot more workshop training available than today. These classes cost \$500 to \$3000 per day. I was always looking for the next one spending 5 to 10k a year investing in my skills while everyone around me said I was wasting my money. Not only have I levelled up in skill, most of the critics have worked for me at some point. Even today when I go to workshops it's only high performers who attend, never the people who need it most. Self-improvement never stops.

12. Don't Accept Excuses

Strong leaders do not accept excuses. Excuses shift responsibility away from growth and improvement. While it may feel supportive in the moment, accepting excuses often reinforces weak habits and prevents people from developing accountability. Leaders understand that every excuse is usually a missed opportunity to prepare better, think ahead, or respond differently. By challenging excuses, they help others focus on solutions and personal responsibility instead of external factors. Over time, this creates a culture of ownership, discipline, and higher performance. Winners accept and take responsibility of everything; good, bad, in-between. Set the standard by refusing to make excuses for your own performance.

Example: When an employee says they were late because of traffic, a strong leader responds by asking what they can do differently next time, such as leaving earlier, instead of excusing the behavior and moving on. Leaders follow thru on discipline even when it's hard. When you're having a tough month and your top guy comes in late, you still hold him accountable. Leaders are consistent. Allowing excuses and inconsistency are 2 of the most common failures in management.

13. Success-Driven

Strong leaders are driven by a deep desire to succeed and achieve meaningful results. They set clear goals and consistently push themselves to reach higher levels of performance. This drive keeps them focused, disciplined, and committed even when challenges arise. They don't rely on external pressure because their motivation comes from within. Over time, being success-driven creates momentum and separates them from those who lack direction or urgency.

Example: When you are success-driven, you are not focused on the money. Your focus is the challenge and the goal. The trophy is reaching the goal. The challenge of reaching for goals, the process itself, becomes the fun part. The money is a byproduct of chasing the success. You never hear success-driven people talking about money, they talk about goals, and dreams.

14. High Standards

Leaders set high expectations for themselves and refuse to settle for mediocre results. They pay attention to quality and continuously push for improvement. This creates a culture where excellence becomes the norm rather than the exception. High standards also signal professionalism and pride in one's work. I believe how you do anything is how you do everything. You should work like you are training someone to do your job.

Example: Leaders know success start from the top and anything they ask of their team they ask of themselves. Leaders know everything they ask of their team will be expected of themselves. High standards command respect.

15. Initiative

Initiative means taking action without waiting for instructions or permission. Leaders proactively identify problems and opportunities and step in to address them. This behavior demonstrates ownership and a willingness to contribute beyond basic responsibilities. It also positions them as problem-solvers rather than passive participants. Over time, taking initiative leads to greater trust and more leadership opportunities.

Example: I've always said if you want the next job start doing it. This doesn't mean stop doing yours it means add to. If you know something needs to be done don't wait for someone to ask just get it done. This example will bleed down to your crew and everyone will eventually follow suit. Leaders never say that's not my job, they just get it done.

16. Not Afraid To Fail

Strong leaders are not afraid to fail because they understand that failure is one of the fastest ways to learn and improve. Instead of avoiding it, they see failure as feedback that reveals gaps in skill, preparation, or strategy. If someone is never failing, it often means they are staying in their comfort zone and not pushing their limits. Leaders intentionally challenge themselves with difficult goals and situations, even when success is not guaranteed. Over time, this mindset builds resilience, confidence, and continuous growth.

Example: I intentionally set goals out of reach then put together a plan to get there. If I know I can hit the goal easily, I might lose interest. It's the challenge that keeps it interesting. I once had a store goal that I thought was out of reach because we had never done it before. I put together the plan, followed it, pushed my team, and we hit it. It raised employee morale, but I wondered: If I set the goal higher how much more could we have done? See, for me, if I'm not failing enough, I'm not pushing hard enough. If I consistently hit my goals then my goals are too safe.

17. Time Management

Time management is the ability to organize and prioritize tasks to maximize productivity and effectiveness. Leaders recognize that time is one of their most valuable resources. They focus on high-priority activities instead of getting lost in low-value tasks. This ensures that important goals are consistently progressed. Over time, effective time management leads to greater output and reduced stress. Time management is also one of the biggest failures I've seen in managers. Showing up without a plan, procrastinating on the not-so-fun tasks always leads to failure.

Example: A leader plans out the next day at the end of the current day, while everything is still fresh on their mind. That way, when they walk into work the next morning, they already have their day and tasks mapped out. Leaders don't waste time trying to catch up, they pre-decide, and pre-plan.

18. Self-Awareness

Self-awareness is understanding your strengths, weaknesses, emotions, and behaviors. Leaders use this awareness to make better decisions and improve their performance. It helps them recognize areas where they need growth and areas where they can leverage their strengths. This also improves relationships because they understand how their actions affect others. Over time, self-awareness leads to more intentional and effective leadership. Leaders who are self-aware surround themselves with people who are better than them in different areas.

Example: One of the biggest problems I've seen in management is refusing to delegate responsibilities. Many managers think it's just easier to do themselves instead of training someone to take on tasks. The problem with that is success is limited to what you have time for. Great managers are aware they cannot do everything themselves and they delegate everything that is teachable.

19. Confidence

Confidence is the belief in one's abilities and decisions, even in uncertain situations. Leaders need confidence to take action, communicate clearly, and inspire others. It allows them to stand by their choices while remaining open to improvement. Confidence also helps others trust and follow their direction. Over time, consistent action and results strengthen this belief. Confidence is built through practice-leaders will practice techniques until they are confident in delivery.

Example: When a leader hears about new technique that sounds promising, he will adopt it, try it, practice, then master it before introducing it to his team. You want to feel confident about new techniques, and as natural in the new skill as if you have been doing it your whole life. It's that confidence that sells the idea to your team.

20. Elevate Others

Strong leaders focus on elevating others, not just themselves, by developing people into future leaders. They understand that building confidence is the first step, especially for those who are new and uncertain, so they consistently provide encouragement and reassurance. As individuals grow, leaders help them connect their work to both financial rewards and a deeper sense of purpose, giving them a strong reason to succeed. Once confidence and results build, leaders challenge their ego in a healthy way by pushing them to compete, improve, and strive to be the best. Over time, they introduce responsibility, allowing high performers to take ownership and mentor others, which ultimately creates the next generation of leaders.

Example: A leader first builds a new salesperson's confidence through encouragement, then helps them find their "why." He later challenges them to outperform others, and finally gives them responsibility to train new hires as they grow into a leadership role. Leaders understand the power of their words and make sure to deliver the words that get the results they want.

21. Courage

Courage is the willingness to take action despite fear, uncertainty, or risk. Leaders often face difficult decisions where there is no guaranteed outcome, and courage allows them to move forward anyway. A manager/leader can not be paralyzed by fear, a leader must make a decision and move forward, even while being uncertain. Leaders “sell” their decisions with courage, to ensure that everyone buys in. Courage is sometimes managing people and holding people accountable even when you are short staffed and can’t afford to lose anyone. You still must have the courage to stay consistent even when it’s tough. Courage sometimes means showing or telling a customer what they don’t want to hear and having the confidence to deliver the message.

Example: A leader has the courage to take chances and expose themselves for possible failure, a leader will take risks and put themselves in vulnerable positions in order to move the store/ team, or themselves, forward. Having the courage to act and do the tough and not-so-fun things is just one trait that separates the top leaders.

22. Persistence

Persistence is the ability to keep working toward a goal despite obstacles, delays, or failures. Leaders understand that meaningful success rarely happens quickly or easily. They continue making progress even when results are slow or setbacks occur. This mindset prevents them from giving up prematurely. Over time, persistence separates those who achieve their goals from those who quit.

Example: Many managers look for shortcuts, or abandon their plans when the going gets tougher than expected. Leaders push through the tough times, stick to their plans, and find a way to win. Leaders adapt and overcome, they don’t run and hide. That is persistence, finding a way despite obstacles.

23. Attention To Detail

Attention to detail is the ability to notice and correct small errors that can impact overall quality. Leaders recognize that minor mistakes can lead to larger problems if left unchecked. They take the time to review and refine their work carefully. This ensures accuracy, professionalism, and reliability. Over time, strong attention to detail builds a reputation for excellence.

Example: There's an old saying: "How you do anything is how you do everything." If you are going to do a thing, do it to the best of your abilities. Work like you are training someone to do the job.

24. Decisiveness

Decisiveness is the ability to make timely and effective decisions without unnecessary delay. Leaders gather relevant information, but avoid overanalyzing to the point of inaction. They understand that waiting too long can be more harmful than making an imperfect choice. Decisiveness keeps progress moving forward. Over time, it builds trust because others see them as reliable decision-makers.

Example: A leader chooses a direction, puts plan together and moves forward. Making adjustments along the way if needed, but never waiting for the perfect time or perfect scenario to get started. We just start.

25. Strong Communication

Strong communication is the ability to clearly and effectively convey ideas, expectations, and feedback. Leaders ensure that others understand what needs to be done and why it matters. This reduces confusion and improves collaboration. Good communication also involves adjusting the message based on the audience. Over time, this skill strengthens relationships and team performance.

Example: A leader gives every employee a list of written job duties and work expectations. Every employee, even management, needs this list. This clear communication alone fixes and prevents problems later. Leaders discuss plans with everyone affected to ensure the team is pulling the same direction. Clear communication not only saves a lot of problems, but also makes everyone feel important, creating ownership in the idea.

26. Listening Skills

Listening skills involve actively paying attention to others and understanding their perspectives. Leaders who listen well gain valuable insights and build stronger trust with their teams. They avoid interrupting and instead focus on truly understanding before responding. This leads to better decisions and fewer misunderstandings. Over time, strong listening skills create a more open and collaborative environment.

Example: A leader is always actively listening, hearing the details in conversation that others may miss. This is trained through solution-thinking and identifying areas of improvement. A strong listener can use this skill in many ways, sometimes it's letting someone voice their opinion, and sometimes it's using their own words to solve a problem.

27. Networking

Networking is the ability to build and maintain meaningful professional relationships. Leaders understand that opportunities often come through connections rather than isolated effort. They invest time in building trust and staying connected with others. I always stay in contact with people in the business, reaching out just to check in. Just keeping myself top-of-mind with my network, keeps my pipeline full and has helped me recruit some of my best guys. Always interview even when you don't need anyone, trying to find people when you need them is hard and often leads to bad hires. Be proactive by keeping your relationships warm so that you can recruit the best talent.

Example: I have a finance guy that I built a relationship with, he runs 4500/5000 a copy and has for years. I stayed in touch with him and popped in every 6 months to say "hi." After 10 years, I finally got the call, "Hey Curtis, I'm ready to make a change." I hired him. Not only did he run 4500 a copy but he showed my other finance managers what's possible. It bought them up over 4000 as well. But it took 10 years of networking to pay off.

28. Self-Control

Self-control is the ability to regulate emotions, impulses, and reactions. Leaders often face stressful or frustrating situations, and maintaining composure is essential. This prevents poor decisions made in moments of emotion. It also sets a strong example for others to follow. A good leader has the ability to never show emotion under pressure. I love when employees tell me that I would have stayed calm even if the building was on fire. This self-control gives you confidence in stressful times. You have to become the filter. Everyone is watching the leader to know if everything is ok, or is it time to panic. Good leaders don't have high highs or low lows, we stay nice and steady.

Example: A leader remains calm and professional during criticism instead of reacting defensively. When you can always stay calm and not make emotional discussions your team will trust and respect you.

29. Optimism

Optimism is maintaining a positive outlook even during challenges. Leaders use optimism to motivate themselves and others to keep moving forward. It does not mean ignoring problems, but rather believing that solutions can be found. This mindset encourages persistence and creativity. Over time, optimism builds resilience and stronger team morale.

Example: During a difficult project, a leader focuses on potential solutions and keeps the team motivated instead of dwelling on setbacks. Leaders control the controllables, we don't spend time and energy focusing on things out of our control. We look for the opportunities that we can control. We find the positive in every scenario and focus our teams attention there.

30. Self-Improvement

This is the most important item on this list. The more you focus on self improvement, the more things naturally start happening for you. It's the law of attraction. Work on improving in all areas of your life: physical, mental, education on topics other than work related skills. Invest in yourself and others will invest in you. Leaders understand that to stay ahead and lead effectively, they must continuously develop new skills and knowledge. They also recognize that people judge them by their actions, not their words, so they lead by example. Over time, their commitment to self-improvement becomes contagious and raises the standard for everyone around them.

Example: I personally have had many of my employee start the gym, start eating better, go to different training workshops etc, in order to show me they want to get better. It starts with wanting to impress me. When they start seeing positive results, it becomes part of their life. Next thing you know they are inspiring someone else and don't even know it. As a natural byproduct you end up more confident, more energy, and a better attitude overall.

31. Structure

Strong leaders build structure into the beginning of their day because they know the first few hours set the tone for everything that follows. They create a consistent routine that prioritizes high-value activities before distractions and unexpected problems take over. Without structure, the day becomes reactive, and important tasks get pushed aside or never completed. Leaders use this time to prepare mentally and physically, organize priorities, and drive early productivity. Over time, a structured start creates momentum, discipline, and a significant performance advantage over others who start their day unprepared.

Example: A leader wakes up early, trains, reviews priorities, inspects operations, and completes key tasks like prospecting or team direction within the first few hours, putting them far ahead before most people are fully focused. Structure and discipline have been one of the greatest tools for my success.

32. Execution

Execution is the ability to turn plans, ideas, and strategies into real results. Many people have good ideas, but leaders differentiate themselves by actually following through. They focus on completing tasks efficiently and effectively. Many people will talk about doing something forever until they talk themselves out of that and start talking about something else. Leaders take action and adjust along the way.

Example: A leader not only outlines a project plan, but ensures each step is completed on schedule until the goal is achieved. Leaders don't overthink or talk, talk, talk, instead of taking action. Leaders get started.

33. Ownership Of Growth

Ownership of growth means taking full responsibility for personal and professional development. Leaders don't wait for others to train or improve them—they actively seek opportunities to grow. They invest time, energy, and sometimes money into becoming better. This mindset keeps them progressing regardless of external circumstances. Over time, it leads to continuous advancement and increased capability.

Example: A professional hires a mentor or coach and consistently works on improving their weaknesses and strengths. In every workshop, training course, etc, that I've taken, I've met winners there. Leaders decide to find ways to grow, they don't wait for someone to tell them they need it.

34. Winner's Attitude

A winner's attitude goes beyond just being positive—it's a deep internal drive to compete, perform, and come out on top no matter the circumstances. Leaders with this mindset show up every day with something to prove, fueled by purpose, urgency, and a refusal to waste time. They don't let conditions like weather, mood, or obstacles affect their standard of performance. This mentality creates consistency and intensity, which naturally influences and elevates everyone around them. Over time, a winner's attitude becomes contagious and sets the tone for the entire team's energy and expectations.

Example: A leader shows up every day determined to succeed regardless of challenges, and their presence alone raises the performance level of the entire team. Winners find a way to win. Winners are only focused on winning while losers are only focused on winners.

35. Influence

Influence is a super power, and people who have the power of influence respect it. Leaders cultivate influence, the ability to inspire, motivate, and guide others toward a goal. Leaders don't rely solely on authority; they earn respect through trust and credibility. Real leaders earn the power of influence through leading by example and holding themselves accountable to the standards they set.

Example: A leader with the power of influence is a great communicator and knows how to tap into the psyche of their people. The power of influence means being able to relate and offer solutions. Influence, when used correctly, is one of the greatest tools.

36. Patience

Patience is the ability to stay committed to long-term goals without becoming frustrated by slow progress. Leaders understand that meaningful results take time to develop. They avoid rushing decisions or abandoning strategies prematurely. This allows them to stay focused and consistent. Over time, patience leads to more sustainable and well-developed success.

Example: I personally am extremely impatient, so I've learned to trick myself with some smaller goals in between the longer term goals. Meeting small goals, gives me those wins I need to continue toward the long-term goal. This may make the long-term goal take a little longer, but for me helps me stay motivated. We have to learn what works for us as individuals.

37. Don't Chase Money

Strong leaders don't chase money directly because they understand it is a byproduct of value, productivity, and helping others succeed. My first closer, Robert Tucker, told me in 2002, "If you help enough people get what they want, you get what you want in return." I still live by those words today. If you're a sales person every customer comes in with a need-your job is to find solutions. As a manager, every salesperson has a need and your job is to find solutions for them. Leaders focus on progress and purpose, consistently improving their performance. Over time, this approach creates stability, growth, and far greater earning potential than chasing quick gains.

Example: Instead of focusing on how can I make more money, focus on how can I improve, how can I help my team, how can I get my store to perform better? This is how winners think and winners are paid on value.

38. Solution Thinking

Strong leaders focus on solutions rather than the problems. They train themselves to see challenges as opportunities to improve, adapt, and grow. Instead of reacting emotionally or panicking, they stay calm and think through the best course of action. This composure builds confidence in everyone around them and creates a sense of stability during uncertainty. Over time, solution thinking becomes a habit that drives faster decisions and better outcomes.

Example: When an issue arises, a leader's first reaction should not be to worry about who is at fault. A leader's first thought is "How do we fix it?" and then learn from it.

39. Feedback Seeking

Feedback seeking is the habit of actively asking for input to improve performance. Leaders don't assume they have all the answers; they look for ways to get better. They welcome constructive criticism and use it to refine their approach. This accelerates learning and growth and self-awareness. Feedback is input to growth. Leaders don't get upset but rather appreciate the opportunity to get better

Example: We tend to want to reject feedback and take it as derogatory. When you are not open to feedback and open to improvement, people will stop coming to you for advice or help. That is a real problem, because the only time you'll know something is wrong is when you get extreme results like losing employees or customers to other dealers who were willing to listen.

40. Progress, Productivity, Purpose

Strong leaders focus on progress, productivity, and purpose rather than just money. Of course we all need money, but when you start looking at money as a byproduct of doing something bigger, you'll find the money comes easier. The reward of progress is far more fulfilling than just money. The combination of the 3 p's creates long-term success instead of short-term wins. focusing on these three areas naturally leads to greater results and fulfillment.

Example: A leader tracks their daily output, works efficiently on high-impact tasks, and stays connected to a deeper reason behind their work, which drives both performance and satisfaction. If you focus your energy every day on productivity and progress that will give you purpose boosting confidence and the (why) and always leads to bigger things than chasing money.

41. Pay It Forward

Strong leaders believe in giving value, support, and opportunities to others without expecting immediate return. They understand that helping others grow ultimately strengthens the entire team and environment. Instead of keeping knowledge or advantages to themselves, they share what they've learned to lift others up. This creates trust, loyalty, and a culture of growth. What you give out often comes back in greater ways through stronger relationships and collective success.

Example: A leader takes time to mentor a new team member, sharing strategies and guidance that helps them succeed, even though there is no immediate personal gain. A leader gives everything away and is not afraid or insecure in teaching their employees everything they know to help their success. One of the greatest joys of being a leader is building up the next leaders.

42. Empowerment Of Others

Empowerment is the ability to trust and enable others to take responsibility and make decisions. Leaders understand they cannot do everything themselves, so they develop their team's capabilities. This builds confidence and ownership in others. It also allows the leader to focus on higher-level priorities. Empowering others creates stronger, more independent teams.

Example: A leader delegates a major task to a team member and gives them authority to make decisions instead of micromanaging. The acronym TDIA: Teach, Delegate, Inspect, Accountability is a helpful device to remember when empowering your team. Empowering your team is what separates good leaders from average managers.

43. Self-Accountability (Extreme Ownership)

Strong leaders take full accountability for everything that happens within their responsibility, without shifting blame to others or external circumstances. They understand that outcomes are a reflection of preparation, leadership, and decision-making. Instead of making excuses, they analyze what they could have done differently to influence a better result. This mindset gives them control and the ability to improve rather than feeling powerless. Self-accountability leads to better performance, stronger leadership, and consistent growth.

Example: If a deal is lost or a team member leaves, a leader reflects on what they could have done differently—such as better preparation, communication, or support—and adjusts their approach for the future instead of blaming the situation. Self-accountability will end excuses and force you to become better

44. Attitude Of Gratitude

Strong leaders maintain an attitude of gratitude, recognizing the value in their opportunities, challenges, and the people around them. Gratitude keeps them grounded and prevents entitlement. It also shifts focus from what is lacking to what is working, creating a more productive and positive mindset. Leaders who practice gratitude build stronger relationships because they genuinely appreciate their team and environment. This mindset increases resilience, satisfaction, and overall performance.

Example: For most of us this, requires a shift of thinking. Its easy to focus on what's missing instead of focusing on what we have. When we train our minds to be grateful for what we have and use what is available, we will maintain a better attitude but we'll be far more productive

45. Humility

Humility is the ability to remain grounded and open to learning, regardless of success or position. Leaders with humility recognize they don't know everything. They are willing to admit mistakes and learn from others. This creates a culture of openness and continuous improvement. Humility builds respect and stronger relationships.

Example: A leader openly acknowledges when they are wrong, and when they need help. A leader is also always open to hearing new ideas or a different way to get something done. A leader is not afraid to bring the best people for the job.

46. Create, Don't Wait

Strong leaders focus on creating opportunities instead of waiting for them to appear. They understand that success is built through initiative, not timing or luck. We take control and build momentum through action. As leaders we give everyone permission through our actions, not our words. Effective leaders create opportunities for our people to gain the confidence to continue when we are not looking.

Example: Instead of waiting for leads or chances to come in, a leader does the things that are not so fun, but required, to succeed. A leader can lead by example, by working together with their salespeople, making calls, working the service drive, calling some trade-up customers from the CRM. A real leader leads from the front and creates action rather than waiting for it to show up.

47. Systems Thinking

Systems thinking is the ability to see how different parts of a process or organization connect and influence each other. Leaders focus on building systems that produce consistent results rather than relying on one-time effort. This helps prevent recurring problems. Over time, strong systems create sustainable success.

Example: A salesman has his 10 Steps To The Sale system. A sales manager should also have a system on how they desk a deal. There should also be a consistent flow. Finance should have a system. Anything that is recurring should have a consistent system in place.

48. Delusional Belief

Strong leaders develop a level of belief in themselves and their vision that others may initially see as unrealistic or extreme. This “delusional belief” allows them to push past doubt, criticism, and limitations that stop most people. They don’t wait for proof before they believe—they believe first, then create the proof through action and persistence. This mindset allows you to take big risks. A leader sets a goal that seems far beyond their current position and pursues it relentlessly, ignoring doubt from others until their results begin to validate their vision. This goes along with not being afraid to fail.

Example. Consider: 2 people have a weight loss contest for 1 month. 1 sets his goal for 10 pounds. The other sets a goal for 30 pounds. The 30 pounds seems ridiculous. But they both shoot for their goal. Guy number 1 hits his goal and loses 10 lbs, guy number 2 misses his goal but lost 16lbs. At the end of the day, a delusional belief and approach will get you a lot further than rational goals. I once set a goal for my store to do 100k over its best month ever. I put together a plan broken down by the week. We exceeded the goal and the only thing I could think was, “Why didn’t I set the goal higher? How much further could we have gone?”

49. Make Today Count

The worst feeling I've had in business is when I give away a day, when I really didn't want to be there and just went through the motions. That drive home is when the regret kicks in and you start thinking of things you should have done. So I made a decision a long time ago that I would never waste another day. Yesterday is gone and tomorrow is not promised, you have today, so make the most of it. We are not going to sell every day and not every day is going to be great. But on the drive home if we know we put in the work and created a productive day when we didn't feel like it, we can hold our heads high with satisfaction and fulfillment.

Example: Here is an example from my personal life. I imagine that if my wife or kids were to ask me, "What did you do for the last 10 or 12 hours that you have been away from us? What have you done to better our future?" Could I look at them and tell them the truth or would I have to lie and sound like I was being productive? Could you tell the truth to your loved ones? Or would you have to make something up?

50. Legacy Mindset

A legacy mindset means thinking beyond personal success and focusing on long-term impact that outlasts your direct involvement. Strong leaders pair this with a bulletproof mindset, staying mentally tough and committed regardless of challenges or setbacks. They also maintain the ability to stay calm under pressure, knowing that their reactions set the tone for everyone around them. This combination allows them to make clear, high-quality decisions even in stressful or uncertain situations. They develop others, and create stability that continues long after they are gone.

Example: A leader stays composed during a high-pressure situation, makes smart decisions, mentors their team through it, and builds systems that continue to succeed even after they move on. To me, a legacy mindset means building something that lasts beyond us. Making a difference, not just being there. To me bulletproof means never breaking under pressure and never giving up on yourself. We may be tempted to give up or break when things become harder than expected, but leaders buckle down and fight through it.

These Are My Top 50 (What Has Worked for Me)

These are my top 50 principles, and more importantly, this is what has worked for me through real experience. Everything here comes from what I've learned, applied, failed at, and improved over time. I'm not saying this is the only way, but I know these habits, mindsets, and standards produce results when you actually live by them. If you commit to applying even a few of these consistently, you will separate yourself from the majority. At the end of the day, leadership isn't about what you know—it's about what you do every single day. Someone who takes 5–10 of these principles and truly applies them daily will see real growth, while someone who just reads them without action will stay in the same place. Nothing replaces action. Take action first, make adjustments later, but get started.



Notes:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins or other markings on the paper.

About the Author

Curtis Rigglesman is a successful Director of Operations who currently manages several dealerships in Central California. He came from a background of poverty. Through determination and a winning attitude, he made his way to the top of his field. His passion is to empower new salesmen and sales managers to confidently engage customers and level up their income.



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1. Dial For Dollars

2.Objections Aren't Real

3. The First Five Sales

4. Built To Lead

5. Closing 101



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